

Affordances: to give a clue

- Refers to an attribute of an object that allows people to know how to use it
 - e.g. a mouse button invites pushing, a door handle affords pulling
- Norman (1988) used the term to discuss the design of everyday objects
- Since has been much popularised in interaction design to discuss how to design interface objects
 - e.g. scrollbars to afford moving up and down, icons to afford clicking on

What does 'affordance' have to offer interaction design?

- Interfaces are virtual and do not have affordances like physical objects
- Norman argues it does not make sense to talk about interfaces in terms of 'real' affordances
- Instead interfaces are better conceptualized as 'perceived' affordances
 - Learned conventions of arbitrary mappings between action and effect at the interface
 - Some mappings are better than others

Activity

– Virtual affordances

What do the following screen objects afford?

What if you were a novice user?

Would you know what to do with them?

